

Qamar Javed Bajwa, completes his extended tenure as chief of army staff—he was given a second three-year term under Imran Khan. A new army chief has to be appointed which, in a country like Pakistan where the army chief is the de facto most powerful person, can result in an entire range of uncertainty.

While indications thus far are that Gen. Bajwa is not interested in seeking a further extension, any such jockeying by him—although it would surely be out of the public eye—could cause its own issues. Aside from the resentment it would generate among top generals whose promotions will get blocked, the recent political drama leading to Imran Khan's removal has also bruised Gen. Bajwa's standing, especially among Imran's passionate supporters who view the military as having "betrayed" their leader.

Add to this uncertainty the expected return of Nawaz Sharif. Nawaz has been in London since October 2019, ostensibly on medical grounds, though he was declared an absconder in 2020 for not returning after the court-ordered deadline for his return. His 10-year jail sentence currently stands suspended by the Islamabad High Court. Whenever he returns—and some PML-N sources claim he might be returning as early as after Eid in early May—he would be looking to have his jail sentence, his daughter Maryam's seven-year sentence as well as their disqualifications from holding public office, which he has termed "politically motivated" and blamed on the military, overturned.

TO GET THE IMF PROGRAMME GOING, THE GOVERNMENT HAS TO UNDO SOME OF IMRAN'S POPULIST MEASURES, LIKE CHEAP FUEL PRICES. THESE WILL BE VERY UNPOPULAR

As it stands, Nawaz has been disqualified for life, while Maryam for 10 years. The PML-N would want at least the charismatic Maryam to be eligible to contest the next elections. The legal battles alone will make for sensational headlines. But whatever their results, they are bound to be hugely controversial and feed into the political uncertainty facing Shehbaz's government.

TOUGH COALITION, FAILING ECONOMY

On a personal level, Shehbaz himself, along with his family members, faces indictments in a mega money-laundering case initiated during Imran Khan's tenure, for which he had already spent time in jail pending a trial. He and his family members are accused of laundering over 7.3 billion Pakistani rupees through fake transactions and the new prime minister is currently out on bail.

Shehbaz also faces a difficult prospect attempting to hold his unwieldy coalition of eight parties and four independents together. All these parties and members of parliament had one common goal—to get rid of Imran Khan, who they saw as having been illegitimately installed by the military's manipulations in 2018—and yet even then they often fell out over tactics and strategy. With power creating its own dynamics, taking everyone along even for a few months might prove to be a difficult task.

Some of the smaller component parties, such as the Muttaheda Qaumi Movement and the Baloch National Party-Mengal, have expectations that go beyond simple allocation of ministries, such as addressing longstanding issues of 'missing persons', devolution to local government and provincial allocation of resources. While these are very important issues, it is not clear whether a short-term government can tackle them in the time it has, particularly since some of the issues need the powerful military and other political parties to agree.

There is also the reality that most of these coalition partners intend to eventually contest elections against each other, and would not like to be seen to be making compromises with their rivals. The largest component of the coalition in Islamabad aside from PML-N is the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), which also governs Sindh province.

The incoming government has vowed to push through much-needed electoral reforms before holding an election. Some of this involves making elections more inclusive and transparent—so that the kind of political engineering that was alleged in 2018 and earlier can be reduced. But some of it also involves undoing or modifying the previous government's ill-thought-out enactments bulldozed through parliament, involving introducing controversial electronic voting machines and allowing Pakistan's over nine million expatriates to vote. These reforms require consensus and are another source of potential conflict.

The political uncertainty only feeds into the real challenge facing the new PM and his allies, however: that of the economy. In his first talk to the press, the likely new finance minister Miftah Ismail claimed that Imran Khan's government had left behind a devastated economy, with record fiscal and trade deficits, a huge debt burden, double-digit inflation, a free-falling rupee and declining reserves.

To get the IMF programme going again—which Ismail admitted will be required to bolster the econo-